Tokyo Travel Guide

Ancient temples and neon streets in the world's largest metropolis - Japan

Tokyo: Overview and History

Tokyo is the capital of Japan and, with its surrounding region, the most populous metropolitan area in the world. It was originally a fishing village called Edo, which became the seat of the Tokugawa shoguns in 1603.

In 1868, during the Meiji Restoration, the emperor moved to Edo and the city was renamed Tokyo, which means Eastern Capital. Tokyo was badly damaged by the Great Kanto Earthquake in 1923 and by bombing in the Second World War, and both times it was rebuilt.

Tokyo hosted the Summer Olympic Games in 1964 and again in 2021 (the Tokyo 2020 Games). Today it is a city of contrasts, where quiet shrines and traditional gardens sit next to neon-lit streets, high-tech shops and some of the world's best restaurants.

Tokyo is a very safe and clean city, and its public transport is famous for being punctual.

Tokyo: Top Attractions

Senso-ji in Asakusa is Tokyo's oldest temple. Visitors enter through the Kaminarimon (Thunder Gate) with its giant red lantern, then walk along Nakamise Street, lined with snack and souvenir stalls. Meiji Jingu is a peaceful Shinto shrine surrounded by forest near Harajuku.

Shibuya Crossing is famous as one of the busiest pedestrian crossings in the world. Next to Shibuya Station stands the statue of Hachiko, the loyal dog. The Shibuya Sky observation deck gives views of the crossing from above.

Tokyo Skytree, at 634 metres, is the tallest tower in Japan. The older Tokyo Tower, painted red and white and completed in 1958, was inspired by the Eiffel Tower in Paris. On clear days you can see Mount Fuji from both towers.

Other highlights include the gardens of the Imperial Palace, the teamLab digital art museums, the Tsukiji Outer Market for fresh seafood, and Ueno Park, which has several museums and is one of the most popular places for cherry blossom viewing.

Tokyo: Neighborhoods and Food

Shinjuku is a giant entertainment district with skyscrapers, department stores, the tiny bars of Golden Gai and the smoky yakitori alley Omoide Yokocho. Harajuku is the centre of youth fashion, especially along Takeshita Street.

Akihabara is known as Electric Town and is the heart of anime, manga and gaming culture. Ginza is an upscale shopping district, and Shimokitazawa is a relaxed area of vintage shops and small theatres.

Tokyo has more Michelin-starred restaurants than any other city in the world. Classic dishes to try include sushi, ramen, tempura, tonkatsu (breaded pork cutlet) and yakitori (grilled chicken skewers). An izakaya is a casual Japanese pub serving small dishes with drinks.

Convenience stores, called konbini, sell surprisingly good onigiri rice balls, sandwiches and hot meals at any hour. Tipping is not customary in Japan and can even cause confusion.

Tokyo: Getting Around and Practical Tips

Tokyo has one of the best public transport systems in the world. The JR Yamanote Line runs in a loop around the city centre, connecting Tokyo Station, Shinjuku, Shibuya, Harajuku and Ueno. Tokyo Metro and Toei subway lines cover the rest. Pay with a rechargeable IC card such as Suica or PASMO.

Tokyo has two airports. Narita Airport is about an hour from the centre by the Narita Express or the Keisei Skyliner. Haneda Airport is much closer and connected by the Keikyu Line and the Tokyo Monorail. Singapore Airlines and Japan Airlines fly between Tokyo and Singapore in about 7 hours.

Shinkansen bullet trains leave from Tokyo Station; the Nozomi reaches Kyoto in about 2 hours and 15 minutes. The currency in Tokyo is the Japanese yen (JPY). Some small restaurants and shops only accept cash, and convenience store ATMs accept foreign cards.

The best times to visit Tokyo are spring, from late March to early April, when the cherry blossoms (sakura) bloom, and autumn, October and November, when the leaves turn red and gold. Summer is hot and humid, and June is the rainy season.

Tokyo: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Visit Senso-ji in Asakusa, take a river boat or walk to Tokyo Skytree, and spend the evening in Akihabara. Day 2: Walk through Meiji Jingu to Harajuku, shop on Takeshita Street, cross Shibuya Crossing and see Hachiko, then enjoy dinner in Shinjuku.

Day 3: Have a sushi breakfast at the Tsukiji Outer Market, stroll through the Imperial Palace East Gardens and Ginza, and visit a teamLab museum.

Kamakura, about one hour by train, is famous for its Great Buddha statue and seaside temples. Nikko is home to the richly decorated Toshogu Shrine. Hakone offers hot springs (onsen) and views of Mount Fuji, as does Lake Kawaguchiko.

Many visitors continue by Shinkansen to Kyoto, or fly onwards to Singapore or Sydney.